

Near-consistent robust estimations of moments for unimodal distributions

Tuban Lee^{a,1}

^aInstitute of Biomathematics, Macau SAR 999078, China

This manuscript was compiled on January 29, 2023

Resistant to departures, current nonparametric robust estimators are inconsistent with population moments. Here, by constructing invariant mean simultaneously for a semi-parametric distribution and a parametric distribution, near-consistent robust statistics (NRSs) are proposed for estimating mean and central moments with insignificant asymptotic biases for common continuous unimodal distributions, such as Weibull, gamma, Pareto, lognormal and generalized Gaussian. This article also illuminates the understanding of the common nature of probability distributions and the measures of them.

quantile inequality | invariant | unimodal | adaptive estimation | U-statistics

The asymptotic inconsistencies between sample mean ($\bar{x}$) and nonparametric robust location estimators in asymmetric distributions on the real line have been noticed for more than two centuries (1) but unsolved. Strictly speaking, it is unsolvable because by trimming, some information about the original distribution is removed, making it impossible to estimate the values of the removed parts without distributional assumptions. Newcomb (1886, 1912) provided the first modern approach to this problem by developing a class of estimators that gives "less weight to the more discordant observations" (2, 3). In 1964, Huber (4) used the minimax procedure to obtain M-estimator for contaminated normal distribution, which has played a pre-eminent role in the later development of robust statistics. In previous work on semi-parametric mean estimation, although greatly shrinking the biases, binomial mean (BM_ϵ) is still inconsistent for any skewed distribution if $\epsilon > 0$ (if $\epsilon \rightarrow 0$, since the alternating sum of binomial coefficients is zero, $BM \rightarrow \mu$). All robust location estimators commonly used are symmetric due to the universality of the symmetric distributions. One can construct an asymmetric trimmed mean that is consistent for a semi-parametric class of skewed distributions. This approach has been investigated previously, but it is not symmetric and therefore only suitable for some special applications (5). From semi-parametric to parametric, an ideal robust location estimator would have a non-sample-dependent breakdown point (defined in Subsection E) and be consistent with any symmetric distribution and a skewed distribution with finite second moments. This is called an invariant mean. Based on the mean-weighted average-median inequality, the robust mean is defined as

$$rm_{d,\epsilon,n} := \lim_{c \rightarrow \infty} \left(\frac{(WA_{\epsilon,n} + c)^{d+1}}{(\text{median} + c)^d} - c \right),$$

where d is for bias correction, $WA_{\epsilon,n}$ is $BM_{\epsilon,n}$ in the first three Subsections, while other symmetric weighted averages can also be used in practice as long as the inequalities hold. The next theorem shows the significance of this composite estimator.

Theorem .1. *If the second moments are finite, $rm_{d \approx 0.375, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ is a consistent mean estimator for the exponential and any symmetric distributions.*

Proof. Finding d, ϵ values that make $rm_{d,\epsilon}$ a consistent mean estimator is equivalent to finding the solution of $E[rm_{d,\epsilon}] = E[X]$. Rearranging the definition, $rm_{d,\epsilon} = \lim_{c \rightarrow \infty} \left(\frac{(BM_\epsilon + c)^{d+1}}{(\text{median} + c)^d} - c \right) = (d+1)BM_\epsilon - d\text{median} = \mu$. So, $d = \frac{\mu - BM_\epsilon}{BM_\epsilon - \text{median}}$. The pdf of the exponential distribution is $f(x) = \lambda^{-1}e^{-\lambda^{-1}x}$, $\lambda \geq 0$, $x \geq 0$, the cdf is $F(x) = 1 - e^{-\lambda^{-1}x}$, $x \geq 0$. The quantile function is $Q(p) = \ln\left(\frac{1}{1-p}\right)\lambda$. $E[x] = \lambda$. $E[\text{median}] = Q\left(\frac{1}{2}\right) = \ln 2\lambda$. For the exponential distribution, the expectation of $BM_{\frac{1}{8}}$ is $E[BM_{\frac{1}{8}}] = \lambda \left(1 + \ln\left(\frac{46656}{8575\sqrt{35}}\right)\right)$. Obviously, the scale parameter λ can be canceled out, $d \approx 0.375$. The proof of the second assertion follows directly from the coincidence property. For any symmetric distribution with a finite second moment, $E[BM_\epsilon] = E[\text{median}] = E[X]$. Then $E[rm_{d,\epsilon}] = \lim_{c \rightarrow \infty} \left(\frac{(E[X] + c)^{d+1}}{(E[X] + c)^d} - c \right) = E[X]$. $\square$

Besides introducing the concept of invariant mean, the purpose of this paper is to demonstrate that the estimation of central moments can be transformed into a location estimation problem and, in light of previous works, a series of sophisticated yet efficient robust estimators can be constructed whose biases are typically smaller than the variances ($n = 5400$, Table 1) for unimodal distributions.

Background and Main Results

A. Invariant mean. It has long been known that a theoretical model can be adjusted to fit the first two moments of the

Significance Statement

Bias, variance, and contamination are the three main errors in statistics. Consistent robust estimation is impossible without specific parametric assumptions. Here, based on a paradigm shift inspired by mean-median-mode inequality, Bickel-Lehmann spread and adaptive estimation, near-consistent robust statistics are proposed for unimodal distributions, while the variances are often smaller than those of the sample moments.

T.L. designed research, performed research, analyzed data, and wrote the paper.

The author declares no competing interest.

¹To whom correspondence should be addressed. E-mail: tl@biomathematics.org

observed data. A continuous distribution belonging to a location-scale family has the form $F(x) = F_0\left(\frac{x-\mu}{\lambda}\right)$, where F_0 is a "standard" distribution. Then, $\frac{x-\mu}{\lambda} = Q_0(p) \rightarrow x = \lambda Q_0(p) + \mu$. Since $F(x) = Q^{-1}(x) \rightarrow x = Q(p) = \lambda Q_0(p) + \mu$. So, any weighted average can be expressed as $\lambda W_{estimator}(\epsilon) + \mu$, where $W_{estimator}(\epsilon)$ is a function of $Q_0(p)$ according to the definition of the weighted average. The simultaneous cancellation of μ and λ in $\frac{(\lambda W_{\mu}(\epsilon) + \mu) - (\lambda W_{BM_{\epsilon}}(\epsilon) + \mu)}{(\lambda W_{BM_{\epsilon}}(\epsilon) + \mu) - (\lambda W_{median}(\epsilon) + \mu)}$ ensures that d is a constant. Consequently, the roles of BM_{ϵ} and median in $rm_{d,b}$ can be replaced by any weighted averages. The biases of $rm_{d \approx 0.375, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ for distributions with skewness between those of the exponential and symmetric distributions are tiny (SI Dataset S1). Therefore, $rm_{d \approx 0.375, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ has excellent performance for common unimodal distributions (SI Dataset S1).

The performance in heavy-tailed distributions can be improved further by constructing the quantile mean as

$$qm_{d, \epsilon, n} := \hat{Q}_n \left(\left(\hat{F}_n(WA_{\epsilon, n}) - \frac{1}{2} \right) d + \hat{F}_n(WA_{\epsilon, n}) \right),$$

provided that $\hat{F}_n(WA_{\epsilon, n}) \geq \frac{1}{2}$, where $\hat{F}_n(x)$ is the empirical cumulative distribution function of the sample, $\hat{Q}_n$ is the sample quantile function. The most popular method for computing the sample quantile function was proposed by Hyndman and Fan in 1996 (6). To minimize the finite sample bias, here, $\hat{F}_n(x) := \frac{1}{n} \left(\frac{x - \hat{Q}_n(\frac{sp}{n})}{\hat{Q}_n(\frac{1}{n}(sp+1)) - \hat{Q}_n(\frac{sp}{n})} + sp \right)$, where $sp = \sum_{i=1}^n \mathbf{1}_{X_i \leq x}$, $\mathbf{1}_A$ is the indicator of event A . The solution of $\hat{F}_n(WA_{\epsilon, n}) < \frac{1}{2}$ is reversing the percentile by $1 - \hat{F}_n(WA_{\epsilon, n})$, the obtained percentile is also reversed*. Moreover, in extreme heavy-tailed distributions, the calculated percentile can exceed the breakdown point of WA_{ϵ} , so the percentile will be modified to $1 - \epsilon$ if this happens. The quantile mean uses the location-scale invariant in a different way, as shown in the following proof.

Theorem A.1. $qm_{d \approx 0.321, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ is a consistent mean estimator for the exponential and any symmetric distributions provided that the second moments are finite.

Proof. Similarly, rearranging the definition, $d = \frac{F(\mu) - F(BM_{\epsilon})}{F(BM_{\epsilon}) - \frac{1}{2}}$.

Recall the cdf is $F(x) = 1 - e^{-\lambda^{-1}x}$, $x \geq 0$, the expectation of BM_{ϵ} can be expressed as $\lambda W_{BM_{\epsilon}}(\epsilon)$, so $F(BM_{\epsilon})$ is free of

$$\lambda. \text{ When } \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}, d = \frac{-e^{-1} + e^{-\left(1 + \ln\left(\frac{46656}{8575\sqrt{35}}\right)\right)}}{\frac{1}{2} - e^{-\left(1 + \ln\left(\frac{46656}{8575\sqrt{35}}\right)\right)}} \approx 0.321.$$

The proof of the second assertion is similar. Since for any symmetric distribution with a finite second moment, $F(E[BM_{\epsilon}]) = F(\mu) = \frac{1}{2}$. Then, the expectation of the quantile mean is $qm_{d, \epsilon} = F^{-1}\left(\left(F(\mu) - \frac{1}{2}\right)d + F(\mu)\right) = F^{-1}\left(0 + F(\mu)\right) = \mu$. $\square$

The definitions of location and scale parameters are such that they must satisfy $F(x; \lambda, \mu) = F\left(\frac{x-\mu}{\lambda}; 1, 0\right)$. Recall that $x = \lambda Q_0(p) + \mu$, so the percentile of any weighted average is free of λ and μ , guaranteeing the validity of the quantile mean. $qm_{d \approx 0.321, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ works better in the fat-tail scenarios (SI Dataset S1). Theorem .1 and A.1 show that $rm_{d \approx 0.375, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$

*Without loss of generality, in the following discussion, only the $\hat{F}_n(WA_{\epsilon, n}) \geq \frac{1}{2}$ case will be considered.

and $qm_{d \approx 0.321, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ are both consistent mean estimators for any symmetric distribution and a skewed distribution with finite second moments. It's obvious that the breakdown points of $rm_{d \approx 0.375, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ and $qm_{d \approx 0.321, \epsilon = \frac{1}{8}}$ are both $\frac{1}{8}$. Therefore they are all invariant means.

It is constructive to consider a symmetric weighted average as a mixture of trimmed mean and symmetric quantile average. Since the quantile inequality is not a necessary condition of the trimming inequality, the safest choice of symmetric weighted average in rm and qm is the $\frac{1}{4}$ -trimmed mean (SI Dataset S1). Using a less-biased symmetric weighted average can generally improve the performance, but the risk of violation is higher in practice. However, another key factor determining the risk of violation is the skewness of the distribution. Suppose there is a near-symmetric distribution S such that SQA_{ϵ} as a function of ϵ is monotonic increasing from 0 to u and monotonic decreasing from u to $\frac{1}{2}$, and $\mu = m$. S does not follow the quantile inequality according to the definition. Depending on the degree of fluctuation, $|SQA_u - m|$, the mean-SWA $_{\epsilon}$ -median inequality in most cases will not be valid for S . Then, the monotonic increase from 0 to u implies that $Q'(\epsilon) \geq Q'(1 - \epsilon) \Leftrightarrow f(Q(1 - \epsilon)) \geq f(Q(\epsilon))$ always holds for $0 \leq \epsilon \leq u$. Similarly, $Q'(\epsilon) \leq Q'(1 - \epsilon) \Leftrightarrow f(Q(\epsilon)) \geq f(Q(1 - \epsilon))$ always holds for $u \leq \epsilon \leq \frac{1}{2}$. Transforming S with $\chi(x)$ will decrease $f(Q(\epsilon))$, and the decrease rate, due to the order, is much smaller than $f(Q(1 - \epsilon))$. That means, as the second derivative of $\chi(x)$ increases, eventually, after a point, $f(Q(\epsilon))$ will always be greater than $f(Q(1 - \epsilon))$, i.e., the SQA_{ϵ} function will be monotonic decreasing and S will eventually follow the quantile inequality. $|\mu - m|$ will increase so that the skewness will increase. Even the transformation is not enough to make the SQA function strictly monotonic; suppose it is generally decreasing in $[0, u]$, but increasing in $[u, \frac{1}{2}]$, since $1 - 2\epsilon$ of the symmetric quantile averages will be included in the computation of BM_{ϵ} , as long as $|u - \frac{1}{2}| \ll 1 - 2\epsilon$, and other parts of the SQA function satisfy the inequality constraints which define the ν th quantile inequality, the mean- BM_{ϵ} -median inequality will still be valid (as an example, the SQA function is non-monotonic when the shape parameter of the Weibull distribution $\alpha > \frac{1}{1 - \ln(2)} \approx 3.259$ as shown in the previous article, yet the mean- $BM_{\frac{1}{8}}$ -median inequality is still valid when $\alpha \leq 3.322$). Accordingly, in a family of distributions that differ by a skewness-increasing transformation, the violation of the mean- WA_{ϵ} -median inequality often only occurs when the distribution is near-symmetric, but the over-corrections in rm and qm are dependent on the WA_{ϵ} -median difference, which is correlated to the skewness, so the over-correction, if it happens, is often tiny with a moderate d . This provides a more general perspective, in addition to the bias bounds (7), that rm and qm based on the mean- WA_{ϵ} -median inequality are generally safe.

B. Robust estimations of the central moments. In 1976, Bickel and Lehmann, in their third paper of the landmark series *Descriptive Statistics for Nonparametric Models* (8), generalized a class of estimators called "measures of disperse," which is now often named as Bickel-Lehmann dispersion. As an example, they proposed a first version of the trimmed standard deviation, $\hat{\tau}^2(F; \epsilon) \equiv \tau^2(F; \epsilon)$, for independent and identically distributed random variables X_i with a distribution F , where $\tau^2(F; \epsilon) = \frac{1}{1 - 2\epsilon} \int_{Q(\epsilon)}^{Q(1 - \epsilon)} y dG(y)$, Q is the quantile function

of G , G is the distribution of $Y = X^2$. Obviously, when $\epsilon = 0$, the result is equivalent to the second raw moment. In 1979, in the same series (9), they explored another class of estimators called "measures of spread," which "does not require the assumption of symmetry." From that, a popular efficient scale estimator, the Rousseeuw-Croux scale estimator (10), was derived in 1993, but the importance of tackling the symmetry assumption has been greatly underestimated. In the final section of the paper, they considered another two possible versions of the trimmed standard deviations, which were modified symmetrically here for comparison,

$$\left[n \left(\frac{1}{2} - \epsilon \right) \right]^{-\frac{1}{2}} \left[\sum_{k=\frac{n}{2}}^{n(1-\epsilon)} [X_k - X_{n-k+1}]^2 \right]^{\frac{1}{2}}, \quad [1]$$

and

$$\left[\binom{n}{2} (1 - 2\epsilon) \right]^{-\frac{1}{2}} \left[\sum_{k=\frac{n}{2}\epsilon}^{\binom{n}{2}(1-\epsilon)} (X - X')_k^2 \right]^{\frac{1}{2}}, \quad [2]$$

where $(X - X')_1 \leq \dots \leq (X - X')_{\binom{n}{2}}$ are the order statistics of the "pseudo-sample" $X_i - X_j$, $i < j$. The paper ended with, "We do not know a fortiori which of the measures [1] or [2] is preferable and leave these interesting questions open."

Observe that the kernel of the unbiased estimation of the second central moment by using U -statistic is $\psi_2(x_1, x_2) = \frac{1}{2}(x_1 - x_2)^2$. If adding the $\frac{1}{2}$ term in [2], as $\epsilon \rightarrow 0$, the result is the same as the standard deviation estimated by using U -statistic (also pointed by Janssen, Serfling, and Veraverbeke in 1987) (11). In fact, they also implied that, when ϵ is 0, [2] is $\sqrt{2}$ times the standard deviation.

To address their open questions, the nomenclature used in this paper is introduced as follows:

Nomenclature. Given a robust estimator $\hat{\theta}$. The first part of the name of the robust statistic defined in this paper is the prefix that indicates the type of estimator, while the second part is the name of the population parameter θ , which the estimator is consistent with as $\epsilon \rightarrow 0$. The abbreviation of the estimator is the initial letter(s) of the first part, plus the common abbreviation of the consistent estimator that measures the population parameter. If the estimator is not a U -statistic, the breakdown point, ϵ , is indicated in the subscript of the abbreviation of the estimator. If the estimator is a robustified U -statistic or a composite estimator, the breakdown point of the location estimator is indicated (except the median).

Naturally, the trimmed standard deviation following this nomenclature is $\text{Tsd}_{\epsilon,n} := \left[\text{TM}_{\epsilon} \left((\psi_2(X_{N_1}, X_{N_2}))_{N=1}^{\binom{n}{2}} \right) \right]^{-\frac{1}{2}}$, where $\text{TM}_{\epsilon}(Y)$ denotes the ϵ -symmetric trimmed mean with the sequence $(\psi_2(X_{N_1}, X_{N_2}))_{N=1}^{\binom{n}{2}}$ as an input. If the square root is removed, it is named as the trimmed variance ($\text{Tvar}_{\epsilon,n}$). It is now very clear that this definition, essentially the same as [2], should be preferable. Not only because it is essentially a trimmed U -statistic for the standard deviation but also because the quantile inequality of the pseudo-sample distribution is ensured by the next exciting theorem.

Theorem B.1. *The second central moment kernel distribution generated from any continuous unimodal distribution follows the quantile inequality.*

Proof. Let $Q(p)$, $0 \leq p \leq 1$, denote the quantile of the continuous unimodal distribution $f_X(x)$. The corresponding probability density is $f(Q(p))$. Generating the distribution of the pair $(Q(p_i), Q(p_j))$, $i < j$, $p_i < p_j$, the corresponding probability density is $f_{X,X}(Q(p_i), Q(p_j)) = 2f(Q(p_i))f(Q(p_j))$. Transforming the pair $(Q(p_i), Q(p_j))$, $i < j$, by the function $\Phi(x_1, x_2) = x_1 - x_2$, the pairwise difference distribution has a mode that is arbitrary close to $M - M = 0$. The monotonic increasing of the pairwise difference distribution was first implied in its unimodality proof done by Hodges and Lehmann in 1954 (12). Whereas they used induction to get the result, Dharmadhikari and Jogdeo in 1982 (13) gave a modern proof of the unimodality using Khintchine's representation (14). Assuming absolute continuity, Purkayastha (15) introduced a much simpler proof in 1998. Transforming the pairwise difference distribution by squaring and multiplying $\frac{1}{2}$ does not change the monotonicity, making the pdf become monotonically decreasing with mode at zero. In the previous semi-parametric robust mean estimation article, it is proven that a distribution with monotonic pdf always follows the quantile inequality, which gives the desired result. $\square$

Remark. The assumption of continuity of distributions is important for monotonicity because, unlike in the continuous case, it is possible to get pairs with the same value for a discrete distribution. For example, let the probabilities of the singletons $\{1\}$, $\{2\}$, $\{3\}$, $\{4\}$ and $\{5\}$ of a probability mass function of a discrete probability distribution be $\frac{1}{11}$, $\frac{4}{11}$, $\frac{3}{11}$, $\frac{2}{11}$, and $\frac{1}{11}$, respectively. This is a unimodal distribution, but the corresponding ψ_2 distribution is non-monotonic, whose singletons $\{0\}$, $\{0.5\}$, $\{2\}$, $\{4.5\}$ and $\{8\}$ have probabilities $\frac{21}{66}$, $\frac{24}{66}$, $\frac{2}{14}$, $\frac{6}{66}$, and $\frac{1}{66}$, respectively.

Previously, it was shown that any symmetric distribution with a finite second moment follows the ν th quantile inequality. That means the quantile inequality does not require unimodality, e.g., for a symmetric bimodal distribution, it also follows the quantile inequality. Examples from the Weibull distribution show that unimodality does not guarantee quantile inequality. Theorem B.1 reveals another profound relationship between unimodality and quantile inequality, which is sufficient for trimming inequality.

In 1928, Fisher constructed k -statistics as unbiased estimators of cumulants (16). Halmos (1946) proved that the functional θ admits an unbiased estimator if and only if it is a regular statistical functional of degree k (17). Heffernan (1997) (18) obtained an estimator of the k th central moment by using U -statistics. In 1984, to study generalized L-statistics, Serfling considered the U -statistic structure (19). Gijbels, Janssen and Veraverbeke generalized the trimmed U -statistics in 1988 (20). Due to the combinatorial explosion, the bootstrap (21), introduced by Efron in 1979, is indispensable in large sample studies. In 1981, Bickel and Freedman (22) showed that the bootstrap is asymptotically valid to approximate the original distribution in a wide range of situations, including U -statistics. After that, the limit laws of bootstrapped U -statistics have been intensively studied and proven by Athreya, Ghosh, Low, and Sen (1984) and Helmers, Janssen, and Veraverbeke (1990) (23, 24). Users can check the accuracy by comparing the unbiased central moments (25) to the bootstrap central moments.

The weighted k th central moment ($k \leq n$) is defined as,

$$Wkm_{\epsilon,n} := WA_{\epsilon,n} \left((\psi_k(X_{N_1}, \dots, X_{N_k}))_{N=1}^n \right),$$

where $X_{N_1}, \dots, X_{N_k}$ are the n choose k elements from X , $\psi_k(x_1, \dots, x_k) = \sum_{j=0}^{k-2} (-1)^j \binom{k-2}{k-j} \sum (x_{i_1}^{k-j} \dots x_{i_{j+1}}) + (-1)^{k-1} (k-1) x_1 \dots x_k$, the second summation is over $i_1, \dots, i_{j+1} = 1$ to k with $i_1 < \dots < i_{j+1}$ (9, 16–18). Despite the complexity, the structure of the k th central moment kernel distributions can be elucidated by decomposing.

Theorem B.2. For each pair $(Q(p_i), Q(p_j))$ of the original distribution, let $x_1 = Q(p_i)$ and $x_k = Q(p_j)$, $\Delta = Q(p_i) - Q(p_j)$. The k th central moment kernel distribution, $k > 2$, can be decomposed as a sum of partial pseudodistributions having the interval $(-\binom{k}{3+(-1)^k}^{-1}(-\Delta)^k, \frac{1}{k}(-\Delta)^k)$.

Proof. Similar to Theorem D.1, when generating the distribution of the k -tuple $(Q(p_{i_1}), \dots, Q(p_{i_k}))$, $k > 2$, $i_1 < \dots < i_k$, $p_{i_1} < \dots < p_{i_k}$, the corresponding probability density is $f_{X, \dots, X}(Q(p_{i_1}), \dots, Q(p_{i_k})) = k! f(Q(p_{i_1})) \dots f(Q(p_{i_k}))$. Transforming the distribution of the k -tuple by the function $\psi_k(x_1, \dots, x_k)$, denoting $\bar{\Delta} = \psi_k(Q(p_{i_1}), \dots, Q(p_{i_k}))$. The probability $f_{\Xi_k}(\bar{\Delta}) = \sum_{\bar{\Delta}=\psi_k(Q(p_{i_1}), \dots, Q(p_{i_k}))} f_{X, \dots, X}(Q(p_{i_1}), \dots, Q(p_{i_k}))$ is the sum of the probabilities of all k -tuples such that $\bar{\Delta}$ is equal to $\psi_k(Q(p_{i_1}), \dots, Q(p_{i_k}))$. The following Ξ_k is equivalent.

Ξ_k : Every pair with a difference equal to $\Delta = Q(p_{i_1}) - Q(p_{i_k})$ can generate a partial pseudodistribution (but the integral is not equal to 1, so pseudodistribution) such that $x_2, \dots, x_{k-1}$ exhaust all combinations under the inequality constraints, i.e., $Q(p_{i_1}) = x_1 < x_2 < \dots < x_{k-1} < x_k = Q(p_{i_k})$. The sum of all the partial pseudodistributions with the same Δ is ξ_Δ . The sum of ξ_Δ , i.e., from $\Delta = 0$ to $Q(0) - Q(1)$, is Ξ_k .

The interval of ξ_Δ is the extrema of ψ_k subject to the inequality constraints. Using the Lagrange multiplier, one can easily determine the only critical point at $x_1 = \dots = x_k = 0$, where $\psi_k = 0$. Other candidates are within the boundaries, i.e., $\psi_k(x_1 = x_1, x_2 = x_k, \dots, x_k = x_k)$, $\dots$, $\psi_k(x_1 = x_1, \dots, x_i = x_1, x_{i+1} = x_k, \dots, x_k = x_k)$, $\dots$, $\psi_k(x_1 = x_1, \dots, x_{k-1} = x_1, x_k = x_k)$. $\psi_k(x_1 = x_1, \dots, x_i = x_1, x_{i+1} = x_k, \dots, x_k = x_k)$ can be divided into k groups. If $\frac{k+1-i}{2} \leq j \leq \frac{k-1}{2}$, from $j+1$ st to $k-j$ th group, the g th group has $i \binom{i-1}{g-j-1} \binom{k-i}{j}$ terms having the form $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1^{k-j} x_k^j$, from $k-j+1$ th to $i+j$ th group, the g th group has $i \binom{i-1}{g-j-1} \binom{k-i}{j} + (k-i) \binom{k-i-1}{j-k+g-1} \binom{i}{k-j}$ terms having the form $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1^{k-j} x_k^j$. If $j < \frac{k+1-i}{2}$, from $j+1$ st to $i+j$ th group, the g th group has $i \binom{i-1}{g-j-1} \binom{k-i}{j}$ terms having the form $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1^{k-j} x_k^j$. If $j \geq \frac{k}{2}$, from $k-j+1$ st to j th group, the g th group has $(k-i) \binom{k-i-1}{j-k+g-1} \binom{i}{k-j}$ terms having the form $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1^{k-j} x_k^j$, from $j+1$ th to $j+i$ th group, $i+j < k$, the g th group has $i \binom{i-1}{g-j-1} \binom{k-i}{j} + (k-i) \binom{k-i-1}{j-k+g-1} \binom{i}{k-j}$ terms having the form $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1^{k-j} x_k^j$. The final k th group is the term $(-1)^{k-1} (k-1) x_1^{k-i} x_k^i$. So, if $i+j = k$, $j \geq \frac{k}{2}$, $i \leq \frac{k}{2}$, the summed coefficient of $x_1^i x_k^{k-i}$ is $(-1)^{k-1} (k-1) + \sum_{g=i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} (k-i) \binom{k-i-1}{g-i-1} +$

$\sum_{g=k-i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} i \binom{i-1}{g-k+i-1} = (-1)^{k-1} (k-1) +$
 $(-1)^{k+1} + (k-i) (-1)^k + (-1)^k (i-1) =$
 $(-1)^{k+1}$. The summation identities are
 $\sum_{g=i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} (k-i) \binom{k-i-1}{g-i-1} =$
 $(k-i) \int_0^1 \sum_{g=i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \binom{k-i-1}{g-i-1} t^{k-g} dt =$
 $(k-i) \int_0^1 ((-1)^i (t-1)^{k-i-1} - (-1)^{k+1}) dt =$
 $(k-i) \left(\frac{(-1)^k}{i-k} + (-1)^k \right) = (-1)^{k+1} +$
 $(k-i) (-1)^k$. $\sum_{g=k-i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} i \binom{i-1}{g-k+i-1} =$
 $\int_0^1 \sum_{g=k-i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} i \binom{i-1}{g-k+i-1} t^{k-g} dt =$
 $\int_0^1 (i (-1)^{k-i} (t-1)^{i-1} - i (-1)^{k+1}) dt = (-1)^k (i-1)$.
 If $j < \frac{k+1-i}{2}$, $i > k-1$, if $i = k$, $\psi_k = 0$, if $\frac{k+1-i}{2} \leq j \leq \frac{k-1}{2}$,
 $\frac{k+1}{2} \leq i \leq k-1$, the summed coefficient of $x_1^i x_k^{k-i}$ is
 $(-1)^{k-1} (k-1) + \sum_{g=k-i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} i \binom{i-1}{g-k+i-1} +$
 $\sum_{g=i+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} (k-i) \binom{k-i-1}{g-i-1}$, the same as above. If
 $i+j < k$, since $\binom{i}{k-j} = 0$, the related terms can be ignored, so,
 using the binomial theorem and beta function, the summed co-
 efficient of $x_1^{k-j} x_k^j$ is $\sum_{g=j+1}^{i+j} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} i \binom{i-1}{g-j-1} \binom{k-i}{j} =$
 $i \binom{k-i}{j} \int_0^1 \sum_{g=j+1}^{i+j} (-1)^{g+1} \binom{i-1}{g-j-1} t^{k-g} dt =$
 $\binom{k-i}{j} i \int_0^1 ((-1)^j t^{k-j-1} \left(\frac{t}{t-1} \right)^{1-i}) dt =$
 $\binom{k-i}{j} i \frac{(-1)^{j+i+1} \Gamma(i) \Gamma(k-j-i+1)}{\Gamma(k-j+1)} = \frac{(-1)^{j+i+1} i! (k-j-i)! (k-i)!}{(k-j)! j! (k-j-i)!} =$
 $(-1)^{j+i+1} \frac{i! (k-i)!}{k!} \frac{k!}{(k-j)! j!}$. The coefficient of $x_1^i x_k^{k-i}$ in
 $\binom{k}{i}^{-1} (-1)^{1+i} (x_1 - x_k)^k$ is $\binom{k}{i}^{-1} (-1)^{1+i} \binom{k}{i} (-1)^{k-i} =$
 $(-1)^{k+1}$, the same as the summed coefficient if
 $i+j = k$. If $i+j < k$, the coefficient of $x_1^{k-j} x_k^j$ is
 $\binom{k}{i}^{-1} (-1)^{1+i} \binom{k}{j} (-1)^j$, same as the summed coefficient.
 Since $\psi_k(x_1 = x_1, \dots, x_i = x_1, x_{i+1} = x_k, \dots, x_k = x_k) =$
 $\binom{k}{i}^{-1} (-1)^{1+i} (x_1 - x_k)^k$, the maximum and minimum of
 ψ_k follow directly from the properties of the binomial
 coefficient. $\square$

ξ_Δ is closely related to $f_\Xi(\Delta)$, which is the pairwise difference distribution, since the probability density of ξ_Δ is $f_{\Xi_k}(\bar{\Delta}|\Delta) = \sum_{\bar{\Delta} = (-\binom{k}{3+(-1)^k}^{-1}(-\Delta)^k, \frac{1}{k}(-\Delta)^k)} f_{\Xi_k}(\bar{\Delta}|\Delta) = f_\Xi(\Delta)$. Re-

call that $f_\Xi(\Delta)$ is monotonic increasing with a mode at the origin if the original distribution is unimodal. So, generally, if ignoring the shape of ξ_Δ , Ξ_k is monotonic left and right around zero. In fact, the median of Ξ_k is also close to zero since it can be cast as a weighted average of the medians of ξ_Δ . When Δ is small, all values of ξ_Δ are close to zero, so the median is arbitrarily close to zero, when Δ is large, the median of ξ_Δ depends on its skewness, but the corresponding weight is much smaller, so even ξ_Δ is highly skewed, the median of Ξ_k will just be slightly dragged away from zero (denote the median of Ξ_k as m_{Ξ_k} , for distributions here, except the generalized Gaussian distribution, $|m_{\Xi_k}|$ s are all $\leq 0.1\sigma$ for Ξ_3 and Ξ_4 , SI Dataset S1). Suppose $m_{\Xi_k} = 0$, for the even ordinal central moment kernel distribution, the average probability density of the left side of zero is greater than that of the right side, since $\frac{1}{\binom{k}{2}^{-1} (Q(0)-Q(1))^k} > \frac{1}{\binom{k}{k}^{-1} (Q(0)-Q(1))^k}$. That means, on average, the inequality $f(Q(\epsilon)) \geq f(Q(1-\epsilon))$ holds. For the odd ordinal distribution, the discussion is harder since it is generally symmetric. Just consider Ξ_3 , let $x_1 = Q(p_i)$ and $x_3 = Q(p_j)$, changing the value of x_2 from $Q(p_i)$ to

336 $Q(p_j)$ will monotonically change the value of $\psi_3(x_1, x_2, x_3)$,
 337 since $\frac{\partial \psi_3(x_1, x_2, x_3)}{\partial x_2} = -\frac{x_1^2}{2} - x_1 x_2 + 2x_1 x_3 + x_2^2 - x_2 x_3 - \frac{x_3^2}{2}$,
 338 $-\frac{3}{4}(x_1 - x_3)^2 \leq \frac{\partial \psi_3(x_1, x_2, x_3)}{\partial x_2} \leq -\frac{1}{2}(x_1 - x_3)^2 \leq 0$. If the
 339 original distribution is right-skewed, ξ_Δ will be left-skewed,
 340 so, for Ξ_3 , the average probability density of the right side of
 341 zero will be greater than that of the left side, which means, on
 342 average, the inequality $f(Q(\epsilon)) \leq f(Q(1 - \epsilon))$ holds (the same
 343 result can be inferred from the definition of central moments,
 344 the positive of odd order central moment is directly related
 345 to the left-skewness of the corresponding kernel distribution).
 346 In all, the monotonicity of the pairwise difference distribution
 347 guides the general shape of the k th central moment kernel dis-
 348 tribution, $k > 2$, forcing it to be unimodal-like with mode and
 349 median close to zero, then, the inequality $f(Q(\epsilon)) \leq f(Q(1 - \epsilon))$
 350 or $f(Q(\epsilon)) \geq f(Q(1 - \epsilon))$ will hold in general. Although the
 351 inequality might be violated in a small range, according to the
 352 discussion in Subsection A, the mean-SWA $_{\epsilon}$ -median inequality
 353 will still be valid for the central moment kernel distribution.

354 A key property of the central moment kernel distribution,
 355 location invariant, is introduced in the next theorem.

356 **Theorem B.3.** $\psi_k(x_1 = \lambda x_1 + \mu, \dots, x_k = \lambda x_k + \mu) =$
 357 $\lambda^k \psi_k(x_1, \dots, x_k)$.

358 *Proof.* ψ_k can be divided into k groups. From 1st to
 359 $k - 1$ th group, the g th group has $\binom{k}{g} \binom{g}{1}$ terms having
 360 the form $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_{i_1}^{k-g+1} \dots x_{i_g}$. The final k th
 361 group is the term $(-1)^{k-1} (k-1) x_1 \dots x_k$. Let $x_{i_1} = x_1$,
 362 $k \neq g$, the g th group of ψ_k has $\binom{k-l}{g-l}$ terms having
 363 the form $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1^{k-g+1} x_2 \dots x_l x_{i_1} \dots x_{i_{g-l}}$, where
 364 $x_1, x_2, \dots, x_l$ are fixed, $x_{i_1}, \dots, x_{i_{g-l}}$ are selected such that
 365 $i_1, \dots, i_{g-l} \neq 1, 2, \dots, l$. Let $\Psi_k(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_l, x_{i_1}, \dots, x_{i_{g-l}}) =$
 366 $(\lambda x_1 + \mu)^{k-g+1} (\lambda x_2 + \mu) \dots (\lambda x_l + \mu) (\lambda x_{i_1} + \mu) \dots$
 367 $(\lambda x_{i_{g-l}} + \mu)$, the first group of Ψ_k is $\lambda^k x_1 \dots x_l x_{i_1} \dots x_{i_{g-l}}$,
 368 the h th group of Ψ_k , $h > 1$, has $\binom{k-g+1}{k-h-l+2}$ terms
 369 having the form $\lambda^{k-h+1} \mu^{h-1} x_1^{k-h-l+2} x_2 \dots x_l$. Trans-
 370 forming ψ_k by Ψ_k , then combining all terms with
 371 $\lambda^{k-h+1} \mu^{h-1} x_1^{k-h-l+2} x_2 \dots x_l$, $x_1^{k-h-l+2} \neq x_1$, the summed
 372 coefficient is $S1_l = \sum_{g=l}^{h+l-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} \binom{k-g+1}{k-h-l+2} \binom{k-l}{g-l} =$
 373 $\sum_{g=l}^{h+l-1} (-1)^{g+1} \frac{(k-l)!}{(h+l-g-1)!(k-h-l+2)!(g-l)!} = 0$, since the
 374 summation is starting from l , ending at $h + l - 1$, the first
 375 term includes the factor $g - l = 0$, the final term includes
 376 the factor $h + l - g - 1 = 0$, the terms in the middle are
 377 also zero due to the factorial property. Another possible
 378 choice is letting one of $x_{i_2} \dots x_{i_g}$ equal to x_1 , the g th
 379 group of ψ_k has $(k-h) \binom{h-1}{g-k+h-1}$ terms having the form
 380 $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1 x_2 \dots x_j^{k-g+1} \dots x_{k-h+1} x_{i_1} \dots x_{i_{g-k+h-1}}$,
 381 provided that $k \neq g$, $2 \leq j \leq k - h + 1$, where
 382 $x_1, \dots, x_{k-h+1}$ are fixed, x_j^{k-g+1} and $x_{i_1}, \dots, x_{i_{g-k+h-1}}$
 383 are selected. Transforming these terms by
 384 $\Psi_k(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_j, \dots, x_{k-h+1}, x_{i_1}, \dots, x_{i_{g-k+h-1}}) =$
 385 $(\lambda x_1 + \mu) (\lambda x_2 + \mu) \dots (\lambda x_j + \mu)^{k-g+1} \dots (\lambda x_{k-h+1} + \mu)$
 386 $(\lambda x_{i_1} + \mu) \dots (\lambda x_{i_{g-k+h-1}} + \mu)$, then, there
 387 are $k - g + 1$ terms having the form
 388 $\lambda^{k-h+1} \mu^{h-1} x_1 x_2 \dots x_{k-h+1}$. So, the combined result
 389 is $(-1)^{g+1} (k-h) \binom{h-1}{g-k+h-1} \lambda^{k-h+1} \mu^{h-1} x_1 x_2 \dots x_{k-h+1}$.
 390 Transforming the final k th group of ψ_k by
 391 Ψ_k , then, there is one term having the form
 392 $(-1)^{k-1} (k-1) \lambda^{k-h+1} \mu^{h-1} x_1 x_2 \dots x_{k-h+1}$. Another

possible combination is that the g th group of ψ_k con-
 393 tains $(g-k+h-1) \binom{h-1}{g-k+h-1}$ terms having the form
 394 $(-1)^{g+1} \frac{1}{k-g+1} x_1 x_2 \dots x_{k-h+1} x_{i_1} \dots x_{i_j}^{k-g+1} \dots x_{i_{g-k+h-1}}$,
 395 there is only one term having the form
 396 $\lambda^{k-h+1} \mu^{h-1} x_1 x_2 \dots x_{k-h+1}$. The above summation $S1_l$
 397 should also be included, i.e., $x_1^{k-h-l+2} = x_1$, $k = h + l - 1$, so,
 398 combining all terms with $\lambda^{k-h+1} \mu^{h-1} x_1 x_2 \dots x_{k-h+1}$, according
 399 to the binomial theorem, the summed coefficient is $S2_l =$
 400 $\sum_{g=k-h+1}^{k-1} (-1)^{g+1} \binom{h-1}{g-k+h-1} (k-h+1 + \frac{g-k+h-1}{k-g+1}) +$
 401 $(-1)^{k-1} (k-1) = (-1)^k + (-1)^k (k-h) + (h-2)(-1)^k +$
 402 $(-1)^{k-1} (k-1) = 0$. The result is the same if replacing x_1
 403 with x_i , where i is from 2 to k , and replacing x_l with other
 404 x_i . Thus, all terms including μ can be canceled out. The
 405 proof is complete by noticing that the remaining part is
 406 $\lambda^k \psi_k(x_1, \dots, x_k)$. $\square$ 407

Consider two continuous distributions belonging to the
 same location-scale family, their corresponding k th central
 moment kernel distributions only differ in scaling. So d is
 invariant, as shown above. The robust k th central moment,
 based on rm here, is defined by,

$$rkm_{d,\epsilon,n} := (d+1) Wkm_{\epsilon,n} - d mkm_{\epsilon,n},$$

where $Wkm_{\epsilon,n}$ is using the binomial k th central moment
 ($Bkm_{\epsilon,n}$ here), $mkm_{\epsilon,n}$ is the median k th central moment.
 Similarly, the quantile will not change after scaling. The
 quantile k th central moment is thus defined as

$$qkm_{d,\epsilon,n} := \hat{Q}_n \left(\left(pWkm - \frac{1}{2} \right) d + pWkm \right),$$

where $pWkm = \hat{F}_n(Wkm_{\epsilon,n})$, $\hat{F}_n$ is the empirical cumulative
 distribution function of the corresponding central moment
 kernel distribution.

Finally, for standardized moments, quantile skewness and
 quantile kurtosis are defined to be $qskew_{d,\epsilon,n} := \frac{qtm_{d,\epsilon,n}}{qsd_{d,\epsilon,n}^3}$ and
 $qkurt_{d,\epsilon,n} := \frac{qfm_{d,\epsilon,n}}{qsd_{d,\epsilon,n}^4}$. Quantile standard deviation ($qsd_{d,\epsilon,n}$),
 robust standard deviation ($rsd_{d,\epsilon,n}$), quantile third central
 moment ($qtm_{d,\epsilon,n}$), quantile fourth central moment ($qfm_{d,\epsilon,n}$),
 robust third central moment ($rtm_{d,\epsilon,n}$), robust fourth central
 moment ($rfm_{d,\epsilon,n}$), robust skewness ($rskew_{d,\epsilon,n}$), and robust
 kurtosis ($rkurt_{d,\epsilon,n}$) are all defined similarly as above and
 not repeated here. The transformation to a location problem
 can also empower related statistical tests. From the better
 performance of the quantile mean in heavy-tailed distributions,
 quantile central moments are much better than robust central
 moments regarding asymptotic bias.

To avoid confusion, the robust location estimations of the
 kernel distributions here are very different from Joly and
 Lugosi (2016) and Laforgue, Clemencon, and Bertail (2019)
 's approach (26, 27), which is computing the median of all U -
 statistics from different blocks based on the median of means
 technique (28-34).

C. A two-parameter distribution as the consistent distribution.

Up to this point, the consistent robust estimation has been
 limited to a parametric location-scale distribution. In practice,
 the location parameter is often omitted for simplicity. In 1894,
 Pearson (35) introduced a family of continuous probability
 distributions, which are now often characterized by the square

Table 1. The performance of invariant moments for 5 common unimodal distributions compared to current popular methods

Errors	TM $\frac{1}{8}$	H-L	WM $\frac{1}{8}$	OSH	BM $\frac{1}{8}$	rm $\frac{1}{8}$	qm $\frac{1}{8}$	Tsd $\frac{1}{8}$	rvar $\frac{1}{8}$	qvar $\frac{1}{8}$	rtm $\frac{1}{8}$	qtm $\frac{1}{8}$	rfm $\frac{1}{8}$	qfm $\frac{1}{8}$
WAAB	0.128	0.109	0.078	0.052	0.057	0.002	0.004	0.237	0.031	0.013	0.025	0.009	0.071	0.018
WAB $_{n=5400}$	0.128	0.108	0.078	0.052	0.056	0.002	0.005	0.235	0.031	0.013	0.025	0.009	0.070	0.019
WSE $\vee$ WSSE	0.014	0.014	0.014	0.015	0.015	0.016	0.017	0.014	0.016	0.018	0.012	0.014	0.012	0.016
WAAB	0.128	0.109	0.078	0.052	0.057	0.003	0.004	0.237	0.007	0.007	0.006	0.005	0.019	0.014
WAB $_{n=5400}$	0.128	0.108	0.078	0.052	0.056	0.003	0.004	0.235	0.006	0.007	0.007	0.006	0.018	0.015
WSE $\vee$ WSSE	0.014	0.014	0.014	0.015	0.015	0.016	0.017	0.014	0.018	0.018	0.016	0.015	0.019	0.017

Errors	m	WM2 $\frac{1}{8}$	SQM $\frac{1}{8}$	SM $\frac{1}{9}$	im $_{b,\frac{1}{8}}$	im $_{v,\frac{1}{8}}$	ivar $_{b,\frac{1}{8}}$	ivar $_{v,\frac{1}{8}}$	itm $_{b,\frac{1}{8}}$	itm $_{v,\frac{1}{8}}$	ifm $_{b,\frac{1}{8}}$	ifm $_{v,\frac{1}{8}}$
WAAB	0.205	0.104	0.057	0.070	0.004	0.003	0.007	0.008	0.006	0.007	0.011	0.023
WAB $_{n=5400}$	0.205	0.104	0.057	0.070	0.004	0.003	0.007	0.007	0.006	0.007	0.010	0.020
WSE $\vee$ WSSE	0.017	0.014	0.014	0.014	0.017	0.017	0.019	0.018	0.015	0.016	0.021	0.018

Errors	$\bar{x}$	im $_b$	im $_v$	var	var $_{bs}$	ivar $_b$	ivar $_v$	tm	tm $_{bs}$	itm $_b$	itm $_v$	fm	fm $_{bs}$	ifm $_b$	ifm $_v$
AAB	0.000	0.001	0.001	0.000	0.000	0.007	0.008	0.000	0.000	0.006	0.007	0.000	0.000	0.011	0.023
RMSE	0.014	0.018	0.016	0.017	0.017	0.021	0.020	0.021	0.019	0.018	0.018	0.028	0.024	0.026	0.029
AB $_{n=5400}$	0.000	0.001	0.001	0.000	0.002	0.007	0.007	0.001	0.004	0.006	0.007	0.000	0.011	0.010	0.020
SSE	0.014	0.018	0.016	0.017	0.017	0.019	0.018	0.021	0.019	0.015	0.016	0.026	0.022	0.021	0.018

The first section uses the exponential distribution as the consistent distribution, while the second section uses the Weibull distribution (*rkurt* or *qkurt* is used for reforming the *ds* starting from the exponential distribution). $BM_{\frac{1}{8}}$ is the weighted average used in robust/quantile moments. The third section uses the Weibull distribution plus optimization (*ikm_v* is invariant *k*th moment, variance-optimized, *ikm_b* is invariant *k*th moment, bias-optimized). The fourth section uses the Weibull distribution for the Weibull distribution; the breakdown points are all $\frac{1}{8}$ (not indicated). The average asymptotic bias (AAB, $n \rightarrow \infty$), average bias (AB, $n = 5400$) and variance (SE $\vee$ SSE, $n = 5400$) of the estimators are in the units of the standard deviations of the kernel distributions (Methods). *bs* indicates the bootstrap moments. W means that the results were weighted by the number of Google Scholar search results on May 30, 2022 (including synonyms). The calibrations of *d* values and the computations of AAB, AB, and SSE were described in Subsection D and Methods. The detailed results and related codes are available in SI Dataset S1 and [GitHub](#).

of the skewness and the kurtosis. Following that, a distribution specified by a shape parameter (denoted as α here) and a scale parameter (denoted as λ here) is often referred to as a two-parameter distribution. Weibull, gamma, lognormal, and Pareto distributions are all two-parameter unimodal distributions. α can be converted to kurtosis, e.g., for the gamma distribution, the kurtosis is $\frac{6}{\alpha} + 3$. If α is a constant, a two-parameter distribution is reduced to a single-parameter distribution. As discussed, for a single-parameter distribution as the consistent distribution and a fixed ϵ , there should be a *k*-tuple ($d_{qm}, \dots, d_{qkm}$) (using a distribution as the consistent distribution means the *d* values used are calibrated by the distribution or the corresponding kernel distributions generated from this distribution). For a two-parameter distribution, let $D(kurtosis, k, etype, dtype, n) = d_{qkm}$ denote these relations, where the first input is the kurtosis, the second is the order of the central moment (if $k = 1$, the mean), the third is the type of estimator, the fourth is the type of consistent distribution, the fifth input is the sample size.

Using the Weibull distribution as the consistent distribution is a problem of robust estimation of parametric models. More specifically, the goal is to find the $qkurt_{Weibull}$ (same for $rkurt_{Weibull}$) such that, $qkurt_{Weibull} = \frac{qfm(pWfm, D(qkurt_{Weibull}, 4, quantile, dtype, n))}{qvar(pWvar, D(qkurt_{Weibull}, 2, quantile, Weibull, n))^2}$. However, the uniqueness of the solution is not guaranteed without knowing the details of the functions. In 1984, Bickel published a paper *Parametric Robustness: Small Biases can be Worthwhile* (36), which deserves to be well-known, and showed that, as its title suggests, small biases often exist and this problem is closely related to robust Bayesian inference (37, 38). The *qkurt* Bayesian-style optimization algorithm for the Weibull

distribution is used here (*rkurt* can also be used, just plugged in), considering that all functions are approximated by a Monte Carlo study at this stage. *qkurt* can iteratively rectify the *d* values. Since the $qkurt_{Weibull}$ can specify d_{qm} and d_{qtm} , this enables the robust estimations of all four moments to reach a near-consistent level for all common unimodal distributions (Table 1, SI Dataset S1). In addition, in 1975, Bickel, presented one-step Huber estimator and proved its asymptotic normality under various conditions (39), implying reliability without full iterations. Again, keep in mind that tiny asymptotic biases might exist when using a two-parameter distribution as the consistent distribution for that distribution (Table 1).

Algorithm 1 *qkurt* for a two-parameter distribution

Input: *D*; *pWvar*; *pWfm*; d_{qfmexp} ; $d_{qvarexp}$

Output: $qkurt_{new}$

$qkurt_{new} \leftarrow \frac{qfm(pWfm, d_{qfmexp})}{qvar(pWvar, d_{qvarexp})^2}$ ▷

Using the *d* values from the exponential distribution as an initial guess, while other guess can also be specified.

2: **repeat**

$qkurt_{old} \leftarrow qkurt_{new}$

4: $d_{qvar} \leftarrow D(qkurt_{old}, 2, quantile, dtype, n)$

$d_{qfm} \leftarrow D(qkurt_{old}, 4, quantile, dtype, n)$

6: $qkurt_{new} \leftarrow \frac{qfm(pWfm, d_{qfm})}{qvar(pWvar, d_{qvar})^2}$

until $qkurt_{old}(1 - \delta) < qkurt_{new} < qkurt_{old}/((1 - \delta))$ ▷
 δ is a small positive number.

D. Variance. As the fundamental theorem in statistics, the central limit theorem states that the standard deviation of

the limiting form of the sampling distribution of the sample mean is $\frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{n}}$. The principle was later applied to the sampling distributions of the robust location estimators (2, 40–46) and it was found that the efficiencies of the robust location estimators are sometimes very different from the arithmetic mean. Daniell (1920) stated (40) that the comparison of efficiencies of the various kinds of estimators is useless unless they all tend to coincide asymptotically. Bickel and Lehmann argued, also in the landmark series (44, 45), that meaningful comparisons can be made by studying the standardized variance, asymptotic variances, and sharp lower bounds of these estimators. Here, the scaled standard error (SSE) is proposed to estimate the variances of all estimators, including robust/quantile moments, on a scale similar to that of the sample mean.

Definition D.1 (Scaled standard error). Let $\mathcal{M}_{s_{ij}} \in \mathbb{R}^{i \times j}$ denote the sample-by-statistics matrix, i.e., the first column is the main statistics of interest, $\hat{\theta}_m$, the second to the j th column are $j - 1$ statistics required to scale, $\hat{\theta}_{r_1}, \hat{\theta}_{r_2}, \dots, \hat{\theta}_{r_{j-1}}$. Then, the scaling factor $\mathcal{S} = \left[1, \frac{\hat{\theta}_{r_1}}{\hat{\theta}_m}, \frac{\hat{\theta}_{r_2}}{\hat{\theta}_m}, \dots, \frac{\hat{\theta}_{r_{j-1}}}{\hat{\theta}_m}\right]^T$ is a $j \times 1$ matrix, which $\bar{\theta}$ is the mean of the column. The normalized matrix is $\mathcal{M}_{s_{ij}}^N = \mathcal{M}_{s_{ij}} \mathcal{S}$. The SSEs are the unbiased standard deviations of the corresponding columns.

Setting the bootstrap moments as the main, the SSEs of all robust estimators proposed here are often between those of the median moments and those of the sample moments (SI Dataset S1). This is because similar monotonic relations between robustness and variance are also very common, e.g., Bickel and Lehmann (45) proved that a low bound for the efficiency of TM_ϵ to sample mean is $(1 - 2\epsilon)^2$ and this monotonic bound is valid for any distribution. Lai, Robbins, and Yu (1983) proposed an estimator that adaptively chooses the mean or median in a symmetric distribution and showed that the result is typically as good as the better of sample mean and median regarding variance (47). It can be seen as an attempt to use the variance version of mean-symmetric weighted average-median inequality. While they used bootstrap standard error as the criterion, another approach can be dated back to Laplace (1812) (48, 49) is using a linear combination of median and mean and the weight is deduced to achieve minimum variance; examples for symmetric distributions see Samuel-Cahn, Chan and He, and Damilano and Puig (50–52).

Algorithm 2 Adaptive optimization of invariant kurtosis

Input: A ; all ivar_{WA} ; all ifm_{WA}

Output: $\text{ikurt}_{\text{opt}}$

```

 $\text{ikurt}_{\text{new}} \leftarrow \text{rkurt}_{\text{Weibull}}$  ▷ other guess can be specified.
2: repeat
     $\text{ikurt}_{\text{opt}} \leftarrow \text{ikurt}_{\text{new}}$ 
4:    $\text{ivar}_{\text{opt}} \leftarrow A(\text{ikurt}_{\text{opt}}, 2, \text{dtype}, n)$ 
     $\text{ifm}_{\text{opt}} \leftarrow A(\text{ikurt}_{\text{opt}}, 4, \text{dtype}, n)$ 
6:    $\text{ikurt}_{\text{new}} \leftarrow \frac{\text{ifm}_{\text{opt}}}{\text{ivar}_{\text{opt}}^2}$ 
    until  $\text{ikurt}_{\text{opt}}(1 - \delta) < \text{ikurt}_{\text{new}} < \text{ikurt}_{\text{opt}}/((1 - \delta))$  ▷  $\delta$ 
    is a small positive number.

```

Scaled standard error enables the direct comparison of variances of different location estimators for asymmetric distributions. Here, two invariant means and related weighted averages ($\text{BM}_{\frac{1}{8}}$, $\text{SQM}_{\frac{1}{8}}$, $\text{WM}_{\frac{1}{8}}$, and $\text{WM2}_{\frac{1}{8}}$ used here) can cre-

ate eight possible combinations. Each combination has an SSE for each kurtosis, which can be generated by a Monte Carlo study here. Then, among eight possible combinations, there is one that has the smallest SSE. Similar to Subsection C, let $A(\text{kurtosis}, k, \text{dtype}, n) = \text{ikm}_{\text{WA}}$ denote these relations. An adaptive kurtosis-specified optimization algorithm is used here to choose the variance-optimum combination (bias-optimum is the same, replacing the SSE by asymptotic bias and then plug in).

The result is almost always as good as the optimum choice (SI Dataset S1) if the distributional assumption is correct. Surprisingly, if the distributional assumption is not correct, the variance-optimized solution might be better than the bias-optimized solution in terms of bias (Table 1). In general, compared to the unbiased sample central moments, the variances of invariant central moments are much smaller (except the second central moment, Table 1). In 1958, Richtmyer proposed quasi-Monte Carlo simulation based on low-discrepancy sequences, which dramatically reduces the computational cost of large sample simulation (53, 54). Do and Hall extended the principle to bootstrap in 1991 (55) and found that the quasi-random approach is competitive in terms of variance when compared with other bootstrap Monte Carlo procedures. By using quasi-sampling, the impact of the number of repetitions of the bootstrap, or bootstrap size, on variance is negligible. An estimator based on the quasi-bootstrap approach can be seen as a very complex deterministic estimator which is not only computationally efficient, but also statistical efficient. The only drawback is that a small bootstrap size can produce additional finite sample bias but can be corrected by recalibrating the d values (18 thousand is used here as default as it balances computational cost and finite sample bias, except the asymptotic value calculation).

E. Robustness. The measure of robustness used here is the breakdown point proposed by Hampel (56) in 1968. However, the sample-dependent breakdown point has apparently not been formally defined previously.

Definition E.1 (Sample-dependent breakdown point). An estimator $\hat{\theta}$ has a sample-dependent breakdown point if and only if its asymptotic breakdown point $\epsilon(\hat{\theta}, R, \zeta, v)$ is zero and the empirical influence function of $\hat{\theta}$ is bounded, where R is the measure of badness, ζ is the contaminating processes, v is the uncontaminated process. For a full formal definition of the asymptotic breakdown point, which is the breakdown point when $n \rightarrow \infty$, and the empirical influence function, the reader is referred to Genton and Lucas (2003) and Devlin, Gnanadesikan and Kettenring (1975)’s papers (57, 58).

Bear in mind that it differs from the "infinitesimal robustness" defined by Hampel, which is related to whether the asymptotic influence function is bounded (59–61). The proof of the consistency of MoM assumes that it is an estimator with a sample-dependent breakdown point since its breakdown point is $\frac{\beta}{2n}$, where β is the number of blocks, then $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(\frac{\beta}{2n}\right) = 0$, if β is a constant or $\beta \ll n$, and any changes in any one of the points of the sample cannot breakdown this estimator (62–64).

For the robust estimations of central moments or other robustified U -statistics based on a robust location estimator, the asymptotic breakdown points are suggested by the following theorem by extending the method in Donoho and Huber (1983)’s proof of the breakdown point of the Hodges-Lehmann

estimator (65).

Theorem E.1. *Given n independent random variables $(X_1, \dots, X_n)$ with the same distribution F and a U -statistic (first generalized by Hoeffding in 1948) (66) associated with a symmetric kernel of degree k . Then, assuming as $n \rightarrow \infty$, $k \ll n$, the asymptotic breakdown point (56, 57, 59, 61, 65) of the robust location estimation of the distribution of the kernel of the U -statistic is $1 - (1 - \epsilon)^{\frac{1}{k}}$, where ϵ is the breakdown point of the symmetric robust location estimator.*

Proof. According to the definition of ϵ -contamination (65), suppose m contaminants are added to the sample. The fraction of bad values in the sample is $\epsilon_U = \frac{m}{n+m}$, while the original n data points are not impacted. That means, in the distribution of the kernel, $\binom{n}{k}$ of total $\binom{n+m}{k}$ points are not corrupted. Then, the breakdown will not occur if the following inequality holds

$$\binom{n}{k} > \left(\frac{1}{\epsilon} - 1\right) \times \left(\binom{n+m}{k} - \binom{n}{k}\right),$$

Since ϵ is the breakdown point of the robust location estimator, $\frac{1}{2} \geq \epsilon \geq 0$,

$$\frac{1}{1 - \epsilon} > \frac{\binom{n+m}{k}}{\binom{n}{k}} = \frac{(n+m)(n+m-1)\dots(n+m-k+1)}{n(n-1)\dots(n-k+1)}.$$

For asymptotic breakdown point, assuming $n \rightarrow \infty$, $k \ll n$, $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(\frac{n+m-k+1}{n-k+1}\right) = \frac{n+m}{n} = x$, then the above inequality does not hold when $x \geq \left(\frac{1}{1-\epsilon}\right)^{\frac{1}{k}}$. So, the breakdown point of the U -statistic is $\epsilon_U = \frac{m}{n+m} = 1 - \frac{n}{n+m} = 1 - \frac{1}{x} = 1 - (1 - \epsilon)^{\frac{1}{k}}$. $\square$

Remark. If $k = 1$, $1 - (1 - \epsilon)^{\frac{1}{k}} = \epsilon$, so this formula also holds for the robust location estimator. In addition, the numerical solutions for $k = 2, 3, 4$, $\epsilon = \frac{1}{8}$ are $\approx 0.065, 0.044$, and 0.033 , respectively. When $\epsilon = \frac{1}{2}$, the robustified U -statistic becomes U -quantile, which converges almost surely as proven by Choudhury and Serfling (67) in 1988.

Discussion

Moments, including mean, raw moments, central moments, and standardized moments, are key parameters that determine probability distributions. The central moments are much more popular than the raw moments because they are invariant to translation. In 1947, Hsu and Robbins proved that the arithmetic mean converges completely to the population mean provided the second moment is finite (68). The strong law of large numbers implies that the k th sample central moment is asymptotically unbiased. Parametrics, semi-parametrics, and non-parametrics are the current three main branches of statistics. Maximum likelihood was first proposed by Fisher in 1922 (69) in a multinomial model and then generalized by Cramér (1946), Hájek (1970), and Le Cam (1972) (25, 43, 70). Besides Newcomb (2, 3), the general robust estimation of parametric models dates back to 1939, when Wald (71) suggested the use of minimax estimates to solve such problems. Hodges and Lehmann in 1950 (72) expanded upon this concept and obtained minimax estimates for a series of important problems. It was soon clear that a minimax estimator should be a Bayes estimator with regard to the least favorable prior

distribution of θ since a minimax estimator is the best in the worst case. The adaptive estimation of the center of symmetry was studied by van Eeden (1970) and Takeuchi (1971) (73, 74). Bickel, in 1982, simplified the general heuristic necessary condition proposed by Stein (75) (1956) and derived sufficient conditions for this type of problem, adaptive estimation (76). As pointed out in Begun, Hall, Huang, and Wellner's paper (1983) and their semiparametric book with Bickel, Klaassen, and Ritov (1993) (77, 78), the two problems, semiparametrics (or adaptive estimation) and parametric robustness, are closely related but different. The paradigm shift here opens up a possibility that by defining a semi-parametric model with inequalities, constructing estimators simultaneously for two or more very different semi-parametric/parametric models within the semi-parametric model, then even for a seemingly "wrong" parametric model that belongs to the semi-parametric model but not belonging to the parametric models used to calibrate, the performance might still be near-optimal owing to the common nature of the models used by the estimators. Maybe it can be named as comparametrics. Lai et al.'s adaptive composite estimator (47) can be classified into comparametrics. Closely related topics are "mixture model" and "constraint defined model" generalized in (78) and the method of sieves, introduced by Grenander (79).

Recently, fascinating statistical phenomena about Taylor's law for distributions with infinite mean were found by Drton and Xiao (2016) (80), Pillai and Meng (2016) (81), Cohen, Davis, and Samorodnitsky (2020) (82), and Brown, Cohen, Tang, and Yam (2021) (83). Lindquist and Rachev (2021) commented: "What are the proper measures for the location, spread, asymmetry, and dependence (association) for random samples with infinite mean?" (84). This is not the focus of this paper, but it is almost sure that the estimators proposed here will have a place. For example, they (84) suggested using median, interquartile range, and medcouple (85) as the robust versions of these moments (86–88). Obviously now, if one wants to preserve the original relation between each moment and at the same time wants the measures to be as robust as possible, the natural choices should be median, median variance, and median third central moment. Analogous to trimmed L-moment (89), which is the most robust version of L-moment (90), the central moment now also has its standard most robust version. As the building blocks of statistics, NRSs provide an option for estimating population moments robustly and near-consistently with moderate variances under mild assumptions, thus improving the consistency of statistical results across studies, especially when heavy-tailed distributions may be present (91–93).

Methods

This section describes the methods for generating Table 1.

The computation of average bias was the same as that of average asymptotic bias as described previously. Here, $\delta = 0.1$, $C = 120$. For the Weibull, gamma, lognormal and generalized Gaussian distributions, the kurtosis range is from 3 to 15 (there are two shape parameter solutions for the Weibull distribution, the lower one is used here). For the Pareto distribution, the range is from 9 to 21.

Standardization is crucial for comparison among different distributions. Currently, there are many choices, e.g., Gauss used the root mean square deviation from the mode, whereas mean absolute deviation and standard deviation are two common choices. Standard deviation is used here because of its central role in standard error estimation. The estimation of central moments based on the

location estimations of the kernel distributions also enables the standardization of ABs and AABs of invariant central moments. The only difference is that the population standard deviation is replaced by the standard deviation of the kernel distribution (σ_{km}).

Then, analogous to the asymptotic bias, the scaled standard error can be standardized, averaged, and weighted (weighted scaled standard error is also defined as weighting the results of the average scaled standard error with the corresponding numbers of Google Scholar search results). It should be noted that in Table 1, for symmetric distributions, generalized Gaussian, the standard errors are used for location and asymmetry estimators, since when the mean value is close to zero, the scaled standard error will approach infinity and is therefore too sensitive to small changes.

Asymptotic d values for the invariant central moments for the exponential distribution were approximated by a quasi-Monte Carlo study (53, 54) based on generating a large quasi-random sample with sample size 1.8 million from an exponential distribution and quasi-subsampling the sample 1.8 million times to approximate the distributions of the kernels of the corresponding U -statistics, then computing the binomial k th central moment (Bkm), median k th central moment (mkm), and corresponding quantiles, finally obtained by the formula $d_{rkm} = \frac{km_{bs} - Bkm_{bs}}{Bkm_{bs} - mkm_{bs}}$ and $d_{qkm} = \frac{pkm_{bs} - pBkm_{bs}}{pBkm_{bs} - \frac{1}{2}}$, where

$pBkm = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n \mathbf{1}_{X_i \leq (Bkm_{bs})}$, $pkm = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n \mathbf{1}_{X_i \leq (km_{bs})}$, bs

indicates the bootstrap moments. The accuracies were checked by comparing the bootstrap central moments to the asymptotic values (errors), showing that for the second, third, and fourth central moments, the errors are ≈ 0.0003 , ≈ 0.001 , and ≈ 0.03 , respectively. The sample standard deviation of the kernel distributions of the second, third, and fourth central moments are 2.234, 9.627, and 60.064, respectively, so, the errors of bias after standardization for the second, third, and fourth central moments were all smaller than 0.001, thus ensuring the accuracy implied in the number of significant digits of the values in Table 1. Invariant moments using other weighted averages, $SQM_{\frac{1}{8}}$, $WM_{\frac{1}{8}}$, and $WM2_{\frac{1}{8}}$, are the same, just plugging in. For finite sample size, $n = 5400$, the d values were calculated by using the Monte Carlo results (1000 pseudorandom samples) with bootstrap size 18 thousands. The errors of d values were calculated by the law of propagation of uncertainty. The computations of ABs and AABs for invariant central moments were just the same as mentioned previously. The SSE was computed by approximating the sampling distribution with 1000 pseudorandom samples for $n = 5400$ and 30 pseudorandom samples for $n = 1.8 \times 10^6$. Common random numbers were used for better comparison. The errors of AB and SSE were calculated by $se(\bar{x}) = \frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{n}} \approx \frac{usb}{\sqrt{n}}$, $se(sd) \approx \frac{1}{2\sigma} se(var) =$

$\sqrt{\frac{\mu_4}{4n\sigma^2} - \frac{n-3}{4n(n-1)}\sigma^2} \approx \sqrt{\frac{fm}{4nvar} - \frac{n-3}{4n(n-1)}var}$, where usb is un-

biased standard deviation of the sampling distribution with normality assumption, μ_4 is the fourth central moment, $kurt$ is the sample kurtosis, var is the sample variance (94). The simulation results and related codes are all included in the SI Dataset S1 and in [GitHub](#).

Data Availability. Data for Table 1 are given in SI Dataset S1. All codes have been deposited in [GitHub](#).

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS. I gratefully acknowledge the valuable comments by the editor which substantially improved the clarity and quality of this paper.

1. CF Gauss, *Theoria combinationis observationum erroribus minimis obnoxiae*. (Henricus Dieterich), (1823).
2. S Newcomb, A generalized theory of the combination of observations so as to obtain the best result. *Am. Journal Math.* **8**, 343–366 (1886).
3. S Newcomb, Researches on the motion of the moon. part ii, the mean motion of the moon and other astronomical elements derived from observations of eclipses and occultations extending from the period of the babylonians until ad 1908. *United States. Naut. Alm. Off. Astron. paper*; v. **9**, 1 (1912).
4. PJ Huber, Robust estimation of a location parameter. *Ann. Math. Stat.* **35**, 73–101 (1964).
5. RV Hogg, Adaptive robust procedures: A partial review and some suggestions for future applications and theory. *J. Am. Stat. Assoc.* **69**, 909–923 (1974).
6. RJ Hyndman, Y Fan, Sample quantiles in statistical packages. *The Am. Stat.* **50**, 361–365 (1996).
7. C Bernard, R Kazzi, S Vanduffel, Range value-at-risk bounds for unimodal distributions under partial information. *Insur. Math. Econ.* **94**, 9–24 (2020).
8. PJ Bickel, EL Lehmann, Descriptive statistics for nonparametric models. iii. dispersion in *Selected works of EL Lehmann*. (Springer), pp. 499–518 (2012).

9. PJ Bickel, EL Lehmann, Descriptive statistics for nonparametric models iv. spread in *Selected Works of EL Lehmann*. (Springer), pp. 519–526 (2012).
10. PJ Rousseeuw, C Croux, Alternatives to the median absolute deviation. *J. Am. Stat. association* **88**, 1273–1283 (1993).
11. P Janssen, R Serfling, N Veraverbeke, Asymptotic normality of u -statistics based on trimmed samples. *J. statistical planning inference* **16**, 63–74 (1987).
12. J Hodges, E Lehmann, Matching in paired comparisons. *The Annals Math. Stat.* **25**, 787–791 (1954).
13. S Dharmadhikari, K Jogdeo, Unimodal laws and related in *A Festschrift For Erich L. Lehmann*. (CRC Press), p. 131 (1982).
14. AY Khintchine, On unimodal distributions. *Izv. Nauchno-Isled. Inst. Mat. Mech.* **2**, 1–7 (1938).
15. S Purkayastha, Simple proofs of two results on convolutions of unimodal distributions. *Stat. & probability letters* **39**, 97–100 (1998).
16. RA Fisher, Moments and product moments of sampling distributions. *Proc. Lond. Math. Soc.* **2**, 199–238 (1930).
17. PR Halmos, The theory of unbiased estimation. *The Annals Math. Stat.* **17**, 34–43 (1946).
18. PM Heffernan, Unbiased estimation of central moments by using u -statistics. *J. Royal Stat. Soc. Ser. B (Statistical Methodol.)* **59**, 861–863 (1997).
19. RJ Serfling, Generalized l -, m -, and r -statistics. *The Annals Stat.* **12**, 76–86 (1984).
20. I Gijbels, P Janssen, N Veraverbeke, Weak and strong representations for trimmed u -statistics. *Probab. theory related fields* **77**, 179–194 (1988).
21. B Efron, Bootstrap methods: Another look at the jackknife. *The Annals Stat.* **7**, 1–26 (1979).
22. PJ Bickel, DA Freedman, Some asymptotic theory for the bootstrap. *The annals statistics* **9**, 1196–1217 (1981).
23. KB Athreya, M Ghosh, LY Low, PK Sen, Laws of large numbers for bootstrapped u -statistics. *J. statistical planning inference* **9**, 185–194 (1984).
24. R Helmers, P Janssen, N Veraverbeke, *Bootstrapping U-quantiles*. (CWI. Department of Operations Research, Statistics, and System Theory [BS]), (1990).
25. H Cramér, *Mathematical methods of statistics*. (Princeton university press) Vol. 43, (1999).
26. E Joly, G Lugosi, Robust estimation of u -statistics. *Stoch. Process. their Appl.* **126**, 3760–3773 (2016).
27. P Laforgue, S Cléménçon, P Bertail, On medians of (randomized) pairwise means in *International Conference on Machine Learning*. (PMLR), pp. 1272–1281 (2019).
28. PL Bühlmann, Bagging, subbagging and bragging for improving some prediction algorithms in *Research report/Seminar für Statistik, Eidgenössische Technische Hochschule (ETH)*. (Seminar für Statistik, Eidgenössische Technische Hochschule (ETH), Zürich), Vol. 113, (2003).
29. JY Audibert, O Catoni, Robust linear least squares regression. *The Annals Stat.* **39**, 2766–2794 (2011).
30. O Catoni, Challenging the empirical mean and empirical variance: a deviation study. *Annales de l'IHP Probab. et statistiques* **48**, 1148–1185 (2012).
31. D Hsu, S Sabato, Heavy-tailed regression with a generalized median-of-means in *International Conference on Machine Learning*. (PMLR), pp. 37–45 (2014).
32. S Minsker, Geometric median and robust estimation in banach spaces. *Bernoulli* **21**, 2308–2335 (2015).
33. C Brownlees, E Joly, G Lugosi, Empirical risk minimization for heavy-tailed losses. *The Annals Stat.* **43**, 2507–2536 (2015).
34. D Hsu, S Sabato, Loss minimization and parameter estimation with heavy tails. *The J. Mach. Learn. Res.* **17**, 543–582 (2016).
35. K Pearson, Contributions to the mathematical theory of evolution. *Philos. Transactions Royal Soc. London. A* **185**, 71–110 (1894).
36. P Bickel, Parametric robustness: small biases can be worthwhile. *The Annals Stat.* **12**, 864–879 (1984).
37. A Marazzi, *Robust Bayesian estimation for the linear model*. (Fachgruppe für Statistik, Eidgenössische Techn. Hochsch.), (1980).
38. J Berger, *Estimation in continuous exponential families*. (1981).
39. PJ Bickel, One-step huber estimates in the linear model. *J. Am. Stat. Assoc.* **70**, 428–434 (1975).
40. P Danielli, Observations weighted according to order. *Am. J. Math.* **42**, 222–236 (1920).
41. PJ Bickel, et al., Some contributions to the theory of order statistics in *Proc. Fifth Berkeley Sympos. Math. Statist. and Probability*. Vol. 1, pp. 575–591 (1967).
42. H Chernoff, JL Gastwirth, MV Johns, Asymptotic distribution of linear combinations of functions of order statistics with applications to estimation. *The Annals Math. Stat.* **38**, 52–72 (1967).
43. L LeCam, On the assumptions used to prove asymptotic normality of maximum likelihood estimates. *The Annals Math. Stat.* **41**, 802–828 (1970).
44. P Bickel, E Lehmann, Descriptive statistics for nonparametric models i. introduction in *Selected Works of EL Lehmann*. (Springer), pp. 465–471 (2012).
45. PJ Bickel, EL Lehmann, Descriptive statistics for nonparametric models ii. location in *selected works of EL Lehmann*. (Springer), pp. 473–497 (2012).
46. P Janssen, R Serfling, N Veraverbeke, Asymptotic normality for a general class of statistical functions and applications to measures of spread. *The Annals Stat.* **12**, 1369–1379 (1984).
47. T Lai, H Robbins, K Yu, Adaptive choice of mean or median in estimating the center of a symmetric distribution. *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci.* **80**, 5803–5806 (1983).
48. PS Laplace, *Théorie analytique des probabilités*. (1812).
49. SM Stigler, Studies in the history of probability and statistics. xxxii: Laplace, fisher and the discovery of the concept of sufficiency. *Biometrika* **60**, 439 (1973).
50. E Samuel-Cahn, Combining unbiased estimators. *The Am. Stat.* **48**, 34 (1994).
51. Y Chan, X He, A simple and competitive estimator of location. *Stat. & Probab. Lett.* **19**, 137–142 (1994).
52. G Damilano, P Puig, Efficiency of a linear combination of the median and the sample mean: The double truncated normal distribution. *Scand. J. Stat.* **31**, 629–637 (2004).
53. RD Richtmyer, A non-random sampling method, based on congruences, for "monte carlo" problems, (New York Univ., New York. Atomic Energy Commission Computing and Applied ...), Technical report (1958).

54. IM Sobol', On the distribution of points in a cube and the approximate evaluation of integrals. *Zhurnal Vychislitel'noi Matematiki i Matematicheskoi Fiziki* **7**, 784–802 (1967).
55. KA Do, P Hall, Quasi-random resampling for the bootstrap. *Stat. Comput.* **1**, 13–22 (1991).
56. FR Hampel, *Contributions to the theory of robust estimation*. (University of California, Berkeley), (1968).
57. MG Genton, A Lucas, Comprehensive definitions of breakdown points for independent and dependent observations. *J. Royal Stat. Soc. Ser. B (Statistical Methodol.)* **65**, 81–94 (2003).
58. SJ Devlin, R Gnanadesikan, JR Kettenring, Robust estimation and outlier detection with correlation coefficients. *Biometrika* **62**, 531–545 (1975).
59. FR Hampel, A general qualitative definition of robustness. *The annals mathematical statistics* **42**, 1887–1896 (1971).
60. FR Hampel, The influence curve and its role in robust estimation. *J. american statistical association* **69**, 383–393 (1974).
61. PJ Rousseeuw, FR Hampel, EM Ronchetti, WA Stahel, *Robust statistics: the approach based on influence functions*. (John Wiley & Sons), (2011).
62. AS Nemirovskij, DB Yudin, *Problem complexity and method efficiency in optimization*. (Wiley-Interscience), (1983).
63. MR Jerrum, LG Valiant, VV Vazirani, Random generation of combinatorial structures from a uniform distribution. *Theor. computer science* **43**, 169–188 (1986).
64. N Alon, Y Matias, M Szegedy, The space complexity of approximating the frequency moments in *Proceedings of the twenty-eighth annual ACM symposium on Theory of computing*. pp. 20–29 (1996).
65. DL Donoho, PJ Huber, The notion of breakdown point. *A festschrift for Erich L. Lehmann* **157184** (1983).
66. W Hoeffding, A class of statistics with asymptotically normal distribution. *The Annals Math. Stat.* **19**, 293–325 (1948).
67. J Choudhury, R Serfling, Generalized order statistics, bahadur representations, and sequential nonparametric fixed-width confidence intervals. *J. Stat. Plan. Inference* **19**, 269–282 (1988).
68. PL Hsu, H Robbins, Complete convergence and the law of large numbers. *Proc. national academy sciences* **33**, 25–31 (1947).
69. RA Fisher, On the mathematical foundations of theoretical statistics. *Philos. transactions Royal Soc. London. Ser. A, containing papers a mathematical or physical character* **222**, 309–368 (1922).
70. J Hájek, Local asymptotic minimax and admissibility in estimation in *Proceedings of the sixth Berkeley symposium on mathematical statistics and probability*. Vol. 1, pp. 175–194 (1972).
71. A Wald, Contributions to the theory of statistical estimation and testing hypotheses. *The Annals Math. Stat.* **10**, 299–326 (1939).
72. J Hodges, EL Lehmann, Some problems in minimax point estimation in *Selected Works of EL Lehmann*. (Springer), pp. 15–30 (2012).
73. C Van Eeden, Efficiency-robust estimation of location. *The Annals Math. Stat.* **41**, 172–181 (1970).
74. K Takeuchi, A uniformly asymptotically efficient estimator of a location parameter. *J. Am. Stat. Assoc.* **66**, 292–301 (1971).
75. C Stein, et al., Efficient nonparametric testing and estimation in *Proceedings of the third Berkeley symposium on mathematical statistics and probability*. Vol. 1, pp. 187–195 (1956).
76. PJ Bickel, On adaptive estimation. *The Annals Stat.* **10**, 647–671 (1982).
77. JM Begun, WJ Hall, WM Huang, JA Wellner, Information and asymptotic efficiency in parametric-nonparametric models. *The Annals Stat.* **11**, 432–452 (1983).
78. P Bickel, CA Klaassen, Y Ritov, JA Wellner, *Efficient and adaptive estimation for semiparametric models*. (Springer) Vol. 4, (1993).
79. U Grenander, *Abstract Inference*. (1981).
80. M Drton, H Xiao, Wald tests of singular hypotheses. *Bernoulli* **22**, 38–59 (2016).
81. NS Pillai, XL Meng, An unexpected encounter with cauchy and lévy. *The Annals Stat.* **44**, 2089–2097 (2016).
82. JE Cohen, RA Davis, G Samorodnitsky, Heavy-tailed distributions, correlations, kurtosis and Taylor's law of fluctuation scaling. *Proc. Royal Soc. A* **476**, 20200610 (2020).
83. M Brown, JE Cohen, CF Tang, SCP Yam, Taylor's law of fluctuation scaling for semivariances and higher moments of heavy-tailed data. *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci.* **118**, e2108031118 (2021).
84. WB Lindquist, ST Rachev, Taylor's law and heavy-tailed distributions. *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci.* **118**, e2118893118 (2021).
85. G Brys, M Hubert, A Struyf, A robust measure of skewness. *J. Comput. Graph. Stat.* **13**, 996–1017 (2004).
86. DC Hoaglin, F Mosteller, JW Tukey, *Exploring data tables, trends, and shapes*. (John Wiley & Sons), (2011).
87. PJ Huber, Robust statistics in *International encyclopedia of statistical science*. (Springer), pp. 1248–1251 (2011).
88. RA Maronna, RD Martin, VJ Yohai, M Salibián-Barrera, *Robust statistics: theory and methods (with R)*. (John Wiley & Sons), (2019).
89. EA Elamir, AH Seheult, Trimmed l-moments. *Comput. Stat. & Data Analysis* **43**, 299–314 (2003).
90. JR Hosking, L-moments: Analysis and estimation of distributions using linear combinations of order statistics. *J. Royal Stat. Soc. Ser. B (Methodological)* **52**, 105–124 (1990).
91. JT Leek, RD Peng, Reproducible research can still be wrong: adopting a prevention approach. *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci.* **112**, 1645–1646 (2015).
92. D Fanelli, Is science really facing a reproducibility crisis, and do we need it to? *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci.* **115**, 2628–2631 (2018).
93. E National Academies of Sciences, et al., *Reproducibility and Replicability in Science*. (National Academies Press), (2019).
94. CR Rao, CR Rao, M Statistiker, CR Rao, CR Rao, *Linear statistical inference and its applications*. (Wiley New York) Vol. 2, (1973).